replied, ‘Bibi, peace is the true security. If there will be peace, there will be security.’ And I responded to him, ‘Shimon, in the Middle East, security is essential for achieving peace and for maintaining it.’”

Peres, of course, could have taken either side in the peace-versus-security argument; at various points in his career, he did. He arguably contributed more to secure Israel’s long-term security than Netanyahu ever has. But then he paid a steep political price for his efforts toward peace—something it is difficult to imagine Netanyahu doing. The prime minister, like many of his contemporaries, is obsessed with short-term tactics, something that would soon come into sharp relief.

It was a funeral for Peres, and the two-state solution—and, for a brief moment in Netanyahu’s speech, it also seemed like a funeral for a bygone era in Israeli politics. He reminisced about another late-night meeting with Peres, in which he asked the president to list his Israeli political icons. Peres, to his surprise, named Moshe Dayan, the legendary general and Labor politician, and he explained why: “Moshe never cared what anybody thought about him… Dayan completely ignored political considerations. He was what he wanted to be,” Netanyahu recalled him saying.

Netanyahu, more than any of his predecessors, is a politician ruled by political considerations, a short-term tactician who lives in fear of his rivals. It wasn’t hard to imagine that Peres meant this as an insult. But Netanyahu utterly missed the point.

Wildfires

For a week at the end of November, a large part of Israel was in flames. The fires started in the north on a Tuesday, in the hilly region between Tel Aviv and Haifa. Others quickly broke out in the south, close to the Gaza border, and in the suburbs of Jerusalem. On Thursday they spread to Haifa itself, which is bordered to the east by wooded mountains. Nearly a dozen neighborhoods were evacuated, forcing more than 60,000 people to flee their homes.

Israel has two seasons: a dry summer and a rainy winter. When the rains are late, the perfect conditions are created for wildfires. This was certainly the case in 2016: Jerusalem had received just 6 millimeters of rain by late November, down from 55 millimeters in a typical year. The northern Galilee was similarly dry, with just 13 millimeters of rainfall, less than a